

Strip Mall Roof Replacement — 32k sq ft TPO, 8 Tenants Occupied, Insurance Deadline

Executive summary — Commercial property manager for 32,000 sq ft strip mall in Pearland, TX, 8 tenants (nail salon, dentist, pizza, etc.), built 2002. Flat roof is original 22-year-old TPO, leaks in 3 bays, inspection shows membrane brittle, seams failing, 40% insulation wet. Trigger: insurance non-renewal unless replaced within 6 months, two tenants threatening rent withholding, owner wants done before August hurricane peak. Budget approved \$180k-\$240k all-in including tear-off, new ISO, 60-mil TPO, drains, parapet flashing, tenant protection, permits, and 20-year manufacturer NDL warranty. Manager selects, owner signs. Constraints: occupied — cannot close tenants, phased in 4 sections with only 2 bays under work at a time, no work during dentist hours Tue-Thu 8am-5pm, nights/weekends preferred, daily cleanup no debris in parking, complete by July 31, permits City of Pearland. Prior: cheap roofer 7 years ago for patch — trash, tenant complaints, worthless warranty; GC last year for parking lot — 30% over budget, 6 weeks late. Owner burned, wants direct licensed roofing contractor not GC subbing to lowest bid. Risks: interior damage liability (\$15k dentist equipment), tenant business interruption claims, deck rot discovery and change-order abuse, paper vs manufacturer NDL warranty. Success in 6 months: roof replaced by July 31 zero closures, 20-year manufacturer NDL in hand, final cost within budget including deck unit pricing, no tenant damage claims, insurance renewed, tenants renew leases.

The decision

Hire a licensed commercial roofing contractor (not GC) to fully replace 32k sq ft 22-year-old TPO roof with tear-off, ISO, 60-mil TPO, drains, parapet flashing, with 20-year manufacturer NDL warranty, phased over occupied 8-tenant strip mall, within \$180k-\$240k, by July 31, with tenant protection and daily cleanup, or delay and risk insurance non-renewal and tenant rent withholding.

Decision maker

Commercial Property Manager — manages 32k sq ft strip mall, 8 tenants, Pearland. Selects contractor, owner approves and signs.

Situation

Property: 32,000 sq ft strip mall, Pearland, built 2002, 8 tenants including nail salon, dentist, pizza restaurant. Roof: flat, original 22-year-old TPO, at end of life, leaks in 3 bays. Inspection last month: membrane brittle, seams failing, 40% insulation wet. Interior: leaks causing damage, dentist has \$15k equipment at risk, other tenants reporting ceiling stains. Insurance: carrier notified, will not renew unless roof replaced within 6 months. Tenants: two threatening to withhold rent due to leaks. Owner: wants asset protected, wants replacement before August hurricane season peak, approved \$180k-\$240k all-in with 20-year NDL warranty. Scope must include tear-off, new ISO insulation, 60-mil TPO, new drains, parapet flashing, tenant protection, daily cleanup, permits through City of Pearland.

Desired outcome

Roof replaced by July 31 with zero tenant closures, phased in 4 sections with only 2 bays under work at a time, nights/weekends preferred, no work dentist Tue-Thu 8am-5pm, daily cleanup, no debris in parking lot, no tenant damage or business interruption claims, final cost within \$180k-\$240k including pre-agreed unit pricing for deck replacement, 20-year manufacturer-backed NDL warranty in hand, insurance renewed, tenants renew leases because job handled professionally, owner sees manager as protecting asset.

Prior experience

- Cheap roofer 7 years ago for patch — left trash, tenant complaints, warranty was worthless paper, no manufacturer backing
- GC last year for parking lot — 30% over budget, 6 weeks late, subbed to lowest bid, owner burned
- No prior full roof replacement at this property — original roof from 2002

Priorities

- Licensed commercial roofing contractor direct, not GC subbing to lowest bid
- 20-year manufacturer NDL warranty — manufacturer-backed, not contractor paper
- Phased work over occupied tenants — 4 sections, max 2 bays under work, no closures
- Tenant protection — dentist Tue-Thu 8am-5pm no noisy work, nights/weekends preferred, daily cleanup, no debris in parking
- Tear-off + new ISO + 60-mil TPO + new drains + parapet flashing included
- Unit pricing for deck replacement upfront to avoid change-order abuse if rotten deck discovered

Constraints

- Budget \$180k-\$240k all-in including tear-off, ISO, TPO, drains, parapet, permits, tenant protection, daily cleanup, 20-year NDL
- Hard deadline July 31 — before August hurricane peak and insurance non-renewal deadline
- Occupied 8-tenant strip mall — cannot close tenants, phased, nights/weekends preferred, dentist blackout Tue-Thu 8am-5pm
- Permits required — City of Pearland, must be included
- Daily cleanup required — no debris in parking lot, tenant business cannot be impacted
- Owner signs, manager selects — must be defensible selection with warranty and references

Options considered

- Do nothing / patch leaks again — risk insurance non-renewal, tenant rent withholding, interior damage liability
- Hire licensed commercial roofer for full replacement with 60-mil TPO, 20-year manufacturer NDL, phased over occupied tenants, within budget, by July 31
- Hire GC to manage roofing sub — lower upfront management effort but repeats prior GC overrun and sub to lowest bid risk owner wants to avoid
- Hire cheap roofer with 10-year paper warranty for \$120k — saves money but repeats trash, tenant complaints, worthless warranty and no manufacturer NDL
- Overlay new TPO over existing — cheaper but inspection shows 40% wet insulation and brittle membrane, overlay would trap moisture and void NDL

Tradeoffs

- Full tear-off vs overlay — tear-off fixes wet insulation and allows deck inspection but costs more and takes longer, overlay cheaper but traps moisture and voids 20-year NDL
- Licensed roofer direct vs GC — direct gives manufacturer NDL and accountability but requires manager to manage, GC easier but repeats 30% overrun and sub to lowest bid
- Phased nights/weekends vs days — nights/weekends protects tenant operations and dentist hours but costs more in labor and lighting

- Unit pricing for deck replacement upfront vs time and materials — unit pricing protects against change-order abuse if rotten deck found but may have higher unit price baked in
- 60-mil TPO vs 80-mil — 60-mil meets budget \$180k-\$240k and gets 20-year NDL, 80-mil longer life but pushes over budget

Risks and concerns

- Interior damage liability — dentist \$15k equipment and other tenants if leaks worsen during project or containment fails
- Tenant business interruption claims if debris, noise, or closure impacts sales — nail salon, dentist, pizza cannot close
- Deck rot discovery leading to change-order abuse — contractor finds rotten deck and charges excessive per sheet without pre-agreed unit pricing
- Paper vs manufacturer NDL warranty — contractor paper worthless if contractor closes, need manufacturer-backed 20-year NDL
- Schedule slip past July 31 — August hurricane season and insurance non-renewal deadline, plus tenant patience
- Permits and inspections — City of Pearland delays if contractor not licensed or submittals incomplete

Unknowns

- Exact extent of wet insulation beyond 40% and deck rot — full extent unknown until tear-off
- Exact deck replacement quantity and unit price that will be charged if rot found
- Tenant tolerance for nights/weekends work — will pizza and nail salon accept night work noise?
- Manufacturer NDL requirements — does chosen TPO manufacturer require specific installer certification and inspection?
- Insurance renewal exact date and whether partial replacement would satisfy carrier or full replacement required?

Decision criteria

- Licensed commercial roofer with manufacturer certification for 20-year NDL, not GC subbing
- Proof of 20-year manufacturer NDL on similar occupied strip mall, with references from property managers
- Detailed phased plan — 4 sections, max 2 bays, nights/weekends, dentist blackout Tue-Thu 8am-5pm, daily cleanup, tenant protection plan in writing
- All-in pricing \$180k-\$240k including tear-off, ISO, 60-mil TPO, drains, parapet, permits, daily cleanup, plus unit pricing for deck replacement upfront in contract
- Completion by July 31 with penalty clause for delay and insurance renewal support letter
- Tenant protection and interior damage liability coverage — insurance, containment, and prior tenant communication plan

Next steps

1. Get core samples to confirm insulation wet percentage and deck condition to set deck unit pricing baseline
2. Shortlist 3 licensed commercial roofers with manufacturer certification for 60-mil TPO and 20-year NDL, with strip mall occupied references, not GCs
3. Request bids with line items: tear-off, ISO, 60-mil TPO, drains, parapet flashing, permits, daily cleanup, tenant protection, unit price per deck sheet, 20-year manufacturer NDL vs paper, phased schedule with 4 sections and dentist blackout

4. Check references from property managers for tenant protection, daily cleanup, and change-order behavior on deck rot
5. Select contractor, get manufacturer pre-approval for NDL, pull Pearland permits, issue tenant notice with phased plan and dentist blackout, schedule July 31 completion with daily cleanup clause and deck unit pricing locked

Recommendation

Proceed with full tear-off replacement by licensed commercial roofer direct with manufacturer certification, not GC, with 20-year manufacturer NDL, phased over occupied tenants in 4 sections, nights/weekends preferred, dentist blackout Tue-Thu 8am-5pm, daily cleanup, unit pricing for deck replacement locked upfront, all-in \$180k-\$240k, by July 31. Do not patch, do not overlay, do not hire cheap roofer with paper warranty. Require tenant protection plan, interior damage coverage, and manufacturer NDL pre-approval before signing. If no roofer meets phased occupied plan and NDL within budget by July 31, negotiate interim insurance extension with carrier letter showing bids and phased plan to avoid non-renewal while securing contractor.

This Decision Brief reflects information provided during the interview. It does not independently verify external facts. Artifact: HTML shown on screen after \$9 payment + Save as PDF, same brief in two forms, no free preview.

Generated: 2026-05-14 • Anonymous session • No login • No database • Server memory only • Session discarded